

- 1) The solid 7 Nf3 when 7...h6 8 Bh4 e5 leads to a position examined in the introduction to the 7...Na6 line of Chapter 2. If Black wants to avoid this then 8...c6 is an interesting alternative.
- 2) The sharpest move is 7 f4 and that is examined in Game 58.
- 3) Another aggressive move is 7 h4. It was quite popular until the world class grandmaster Bareev lost a lot of games with it! A good line for Black is 7...e5 8 d5 h6 9 Be3 Nc5 10 Qc2 (10 f3 is well met by 10...Nh5) 10...c6! (Diagram 8)

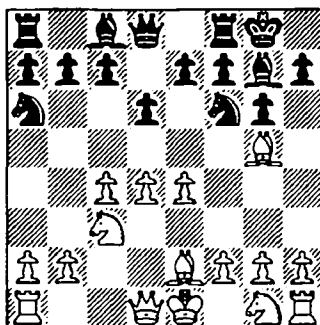


Diagram 7
Black prepares ...e7-e5

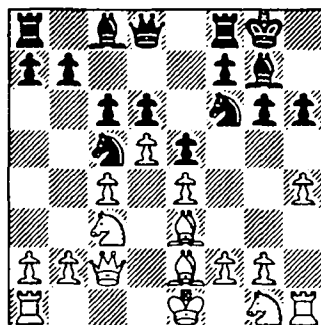


Diagram 8
Undermining the centre



NOTE: Black should open lines on the queenside at once White starts advancing his kingside pawns. See also the chapter on h3 Systems.

Exercise 9: Where does the knight go after 11 b4?

White should play 11 h5 with an unclear game after 11...cxd5 12 cxd5 Qa5.

7...e5 8 d5

8 dxe5 dxe5 9 Qxd8 Rxd8 10 Nd5 no longer concerns Black as with the knight on a6 defending c7 he can just play 10...Rd6. Nor does 10 Nxe5 cause Black any problems because of the reply 10...Nxe4!

8...c6

Here, too, White is planning to push his kingside pawns so Black opens the queenside. This line is covered in Game 57. 8...Qe8 and 8...Nc5 are quite reasonable alternatives.

Theoretical?

A general understanding of how to play the King's Indian is more important than theory in this variation. Slight slips are unlikely to be fatal in the opening.

Statistics

We mentioned above how well the Averbakh scores in general. Against 6...Na6 its fortunes are rather mixed. With the main line 7 Qd2 White scores only 48% from nearly 500 games, but the sharp 7 f4 does much better, registering 63% from 135 games.

Illustrative Games

Game 57

□ Isoseliani ■ Gallagher

Biel 1990

1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nc3 Bg7 4 e4 d6 5 Be2 0-0 6 Bg5 Na6 7 Qd2 e5
8 d5 c6 9 f3

White defends the e-pawn and prepares to advance on the kingside.

9...cxd5 10 cxd5 Bd7 11 h4

11 g4 Qa5 12 Nh3 is less promising for Black. It is better to play 11...h6! 12 Be3 (12 Bxh6 Nxe4 13 Nxe4 Qh4+) 12...h5 13 h3 (13 g5 Nh7 14 h4 f6) 13...Nc5 14 0-0-0 Qb8 or 14...Qe8 to prepare ...b5. The chances are roughly equal.

11...Qa5 12 g4 h5! (Diagram 9)

This sort of pawn sacrifice is what the King's Indian is all about. Instead of submitting to White's will on the kingside Black battles for the initiative. To take the pawn White now has to give up the important dark-squared bishop.

13 Bxf6 Bxf6 14 gxf5 Kg7!

This is a key move which prepares ...Rh8 and rules out any invasion of the white queen on h6.

15 hxg6 fxg6 16 h5 Rh8! 17 h6+ Kh7

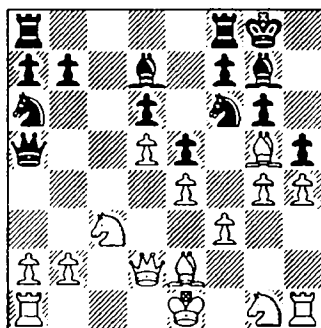


Diagram 9

Black opens the kingside!

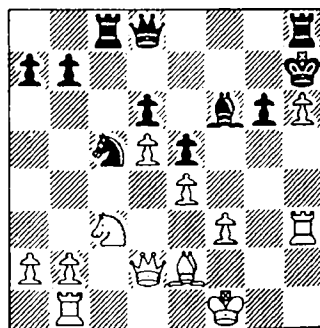


Diagram 10

White's king is in more danger

Did you think the black king was in danger? Well it isn't anymore (and never was). One couldn't ask for better protection than that offered by the pawn on h6. White won't even be able to sacrifice a piece for it. In fact, it is the white king that is starting to feel the draught. The queenside is full of holes so he prefers to make his home on g2.

18 Nh3 Bxh3! 19 Rxh3 Rac8 20 Kf1 Nc5 21 Rb1 Qd8! (Diagram 10)

The black pieces follow the white king to the kingside. White really begins to miss the dark-squared bishop now.

22 Kg2 Bg5 23 Qe1 Nd7 24 Qg3 Bf4 25 Qg4 Re8!

This keeps the white queen out of e6 and it will soon be driven back by the knight.

26 Kh1 Nf6 27 Qg2 Rg8 28 Bd3 Qd7 29 Bb5 Qf7 30 Bd3 g5 31 Ne2 Rg6 32 Qf2 a6 33 Ng3 Bxg3

The knight must not get to f5 and Black is more than happy to transform his advantage into a good knight versus awful bishop position.

34 Qxg3 Rxh6 35 Rg1 Rxh3+ 36 Qxh3+ Qh5 37 Qxh5+ Nxh5 38 Rg2

38 Rg5 Nf4 39 Bb1 Rc4! followed by ...Rd4 would have been equally unpleasant. The extra pawn is useless.

38...Nf4 39 Rc2 Rxc2 40 Bxc2 Kg6 41 Kg1 Kh5 42 Kf2 Kh4 43 b4 b6 44 a3 Kh3 45 Ba4 Kh2 (Diagram 11)

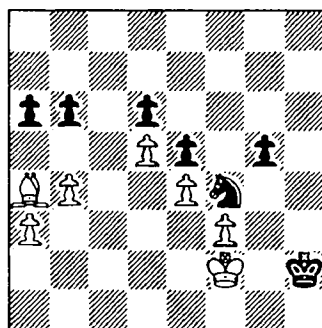


Diagram 11

Good knight vs bad bishop

The endgame is lost because a knight check at an appropriate moment will always force the white king to give ground.

46 Bd7 Nh3+ 47 Ke3 Kg2 48 Bc8 a5 49 bxa5 bxa5 50 Bf5 Nf2 51 Bd7 Kg3 52 Bc8 Nd1+ 53 Kd2 Nf2 54 Ke3 Nd1+ 55 Kd2 Nb2 56 Ke2 Nc4 57 Ba6 Nb6

Certainly not 57...Nxa3? 58 Bd3! when the black knight is trapped.

Starting Out: The King's Indian

58 Ke3 Nd7 59 Bb5 Nf6 60 Be2 Nh5 61 Bb5 Nf4 62 Be8 Ng2+ 63 Ke2 Kf4 64 Bd7 Ne3 65 Ba4 g4! 66 fxe4 Nxe4 67 Kd3 Nf2+ 68 Ke4 Nxe4 69 Bc2 Ng3 70 Kb5 e4 71 Kxa5 e3 72 Bd1 e2 73 Bxe2 Nxe2 74 Kb4 Ke5 75 a4 Kxd5 76 a5 Nd4 77 a6 Ne6 White resigns

Game 58

□ S.Mohr ■ Uhlmann

Bundesliga 1994-95

1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nc3 Bg7 4 e4 d6 5 Be2 0-0 6 Bg5 Na6 7 f4!?

An aggressive move which leads to a strange version of the Four Pawns Attack. There are dangers for the white bishop outside the pawn chain but, on the other hand, Black is now prevented from playing ...e7-e5, and ...c7-c5 is not very promising with the knight on a6.

7...c6!?

This modest-looking move is probably best. Black plans to bring his knight back into play via c7 and establish a foothold in the centre by playing ...d6-d5. Most unusual for the King's Indian.

8 Nf3 Nc7 9 Qd2

White defends the f-pawn, so that 9...Ne6 can be met by 10 Bh4. There are a couple of alternatives

1) The prophylactic retreat 9 Bh4 is becoming increasingly popular. After 9...d5 10 e5 Ne4 we can already see the benefit of 9 Bh4 – the bishop is not attacked. Still, I think Black's position is all right after both 11 Nxe4 dxe4 12 Ng5 f6 13 exf6 exf6 14 Nxe4 Ne6 and 11 0-0 Bf5 12 Nxe4 Bxe4 13 Ng5 Bf5 14 g4 Bc8 15 f5 f6!.

2) 9 d5 is a more radical way to prevent ...Ne6 but 9...cxd5 10 cxd5 Nh5!, threatening ...f7-f6, gives Black reasonable play

9...d5 (Diagram 12)

Finally Black reacts in the centre

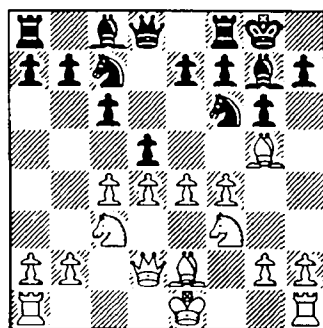


Diagram 12

An unusual thrust in the King's Indian

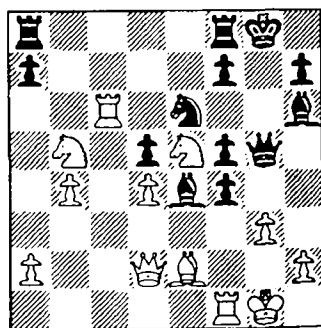


Diagram 13

Preparing the final assault

10 Bxf6

10 e5 is of course met by 10...Ne4.

10...exf6!

Black breaks the rules as after the natural 10...Bxf6 11 cxd5 cxd5 12 e5 Bg7 13 h4! White has attacking chances and a space advantage.

11 exd5

11 0-0 is well met by 11...dxe4 12 Nxe4 Bg4! when, by eliminating the knight on f3, Black will get pressure against d4.

11...cxd5 12 c5 Bf5!

Black is going to park his bishop on e4 and if White ever takes it will then be replaced by a strong passed pawn.

13 0-0 Be4 14 b4 Ne6 15 Rac1 f5 16 Nb5?!

Now White won't be able to remove the bishop on e4.

16...Bh6! 17 g3 g5!

Uhlmann still packs a punch even in his eighth decade.

18 Ne5? gxf4 19 c6 bxc6 20 Rxc6 Qg5 (Diagram 13)

Black was unable to play ...fxg3 on the previous move as the f4-pawn was pinned to his bishop on h6. Now with Black threatening this capture White can find nothing better than a desperate piece sacrifice.

21 Nxf7 Kxf7 22 Nd6+ Ke7 23 Nxe4 fxe4 24 b5 f3 25 Qb4+ Kf7 26 Qd6 Rae8 27 Bxf3 Kg8! 28 Bg2 Qe3+ 29 Kh1 Rxf1+ 30 Bxf1 Qf3+ White resigns

It's mate in two.

Summary

- 1) Don't play 6...e5!. It loses.
- 2) The lines with ...c7-c5 are perfectly playable for Black but by playing dxc5 White can steer the game into the sort of position that few King's Indian players feel really at home in.
- 3) In some ways the move 6...Na6 has disarmed the Averbakh. Black is now able to play ...e7-e5 without making any real concessions. As always with a knight on a6 Black should make sure that it doesn't stay stuck there out of play. This is particularly important when White plays 7 f4. There is an old saying: One badly placed piece makes the whole position bad.